

Worksheet 3: Facing It, One Step at a Time (ERP Practice Log)

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This is the log we use during exposure and response prevention (ERP). Each practice means: face a rung from your ladder, and stay with it WITHOUT doing the coping reaction, until the distress starts to come down on its own. We start low and always supervised. You lead the pace.

Every session begins with a quick safety check. If suicidal thoughts are active or risk is up, we pause ERP and focus on safety first. Exposure to knives / cutters / rope is only done in session, supervised, with means secured. Never practise those items alone.

Why this works (remind myself)

- The thought is not a danger - it is just a thought my brain flags by mistake.
- The reaction (avoiding, checking, scratching, reassurance) is what keeps the fear alive.
- If I stay with the thought and do nothing, my brain learns it is safe, and the fear fades.
- Distress always comes down eventually - I do not have to fix it.

Before the practice

Session no. / date: _____

Safety check done? Yes / No Risk stable enough to proceed? Yes / No

Rung I am practising today: _____

Type: In-vivo / Imaginal (circle)

Reactions I will HOLD BACK today: _____

Safe skill instead of scratching/holding: _____

During the practice - track distress every few minutes

Rate SUDS (0-100) at the start, and then every 2-5 minutes while you stay with it. The goal is NOT to make it drop fast - it is to STAY without the reaction and watch what happens.

Time point	SUDS (0-100)	Did I do any reaction? (what?)
Start		
+ few min		
+ few min		
+ few min		
+ few min		
End		

Highest SUDS reached: _____ Lowest by the end: _____

After the practice - what I learned

Did I act on the thought? No (this is the evidence that matters most)

What actually happened vs. what I feared would happen?

What does this tell me about the thought?

Between-session practice (homework)

Repeat the same rung on your own only if it is on the agreed 'safe to practise alone' list. Family can support you by NOT giving reassurance and NOT policing you - just being calm and present.

Day	Rung practised	Start SUDS	End SUDS	Reaction resisted? (Y/N)
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Moving up the ladder

Move to the next rung only when the current one drops to about half its starting SUDS and feels much easier across a few practices. Write the date you 'graduated' each rung.

Rung	First SUDS	Now feels like	Graduated (date)

If distress ever feels unmanageable, or self-harm/suicidal urges rise: stop the exposure, use the safe skill, and tell the clinician or a parent immediately. Slowing down is allowed - it is not failure.